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Summarize the 1906 San Francisco Earthquake. What factors shaped the current landscape?

The **1906 San Francisco Earthquake** struck on April 18, 1906, and was one of the most devastating natural disasters in U.S. history.

Summary of the event:

- A powerful earthquake (estimated magnitude ~7.8) ruptured along the **San Andreas Fault**.
- The shaking lasted less than a minute but caused widespread structural collapse.
- **Fires**, ignited by broken gas lines and worsened by damaged water systems, burned for several days and destroyed much of the city.
- About **3,000 people died**, and over **200,000 were left homeless**.
- Roughly **80% of San Francisco** was destroyed.

Factors that shaped today's landscape:

1. **Rebuilding and Urban Planning**
   - The city was rapidly rebuilt, often on the same street grid, but with **wider streets**, improved infrastructure, and more organized neighborhoods.
   - Some proposed radical redesigns (like grand boulevards) were rejected, preserving much of the original layout.
2. **Building Codes and Engineering**
   - The disaster led to stronger **earthquake-resistant building standards**, influencing modern construction across California.
   - Use of steel-frame buildings and reinforced materials became more common.
3. **Fire Management Systems**
   - The failure of water mains led to improved **firefighting infrastructure**, including reservoirs, firebreaks, and emergency water systems.
4. **Geological Awareness**
   - Recognition of the **San Andreas Fault system** reshaped scientific understanding of earthquakes.
   - Modern hazard mapping and land-use planning now consider fault lines and unstable ground.
5. **Population and Economic Shifts**
   - Displacement temporarily shifted population and business to nearby areas (like Oakland), but San Francisco quickly reestablished itself as a major economic hub.
6. **Landscape Alterations**
   - Rubble from the quake and fires was used to **fill parts of the shoreline**, expanding land areas.
   - Some neighborhoods today sit on **artificial fill**, which affects how they respond to earthquakes (e.g., liquefaction risk).

In short:
The 1906 earthquake didn't just destroy San Francisco—it reshaped it. Modern building practices, emergency systems, and even parts of the city's physical geography are direct results of how the city responded and rebuilt after the disaster.

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